Dirac operators in coarse geometry

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1 Overview

Dirac operators occur in differential geometry, global analysis, and mathematical physics. They connect local geometric data with global spectral invariants. The main purpose of this course is to explain one part of this connection: how a Dirac operator on a complete Riemannian manifold determines an index class which remembers the large-scale geometry of the manifold.

The main construction has the form

$$D \longmapsto \operatorname{ind} \mathcal{X}(D) \in K\mathcal{X}_*(M).$$

Here $K\mathcal{X}(M)$ denotes the complex coarse K-homology spectrum of M (Definition 8.18). The index relates the large-scale geometry of M to the spectral and localization properties of D near zero. Its degree is determined by the grading and Clifford symmetries of D. The analytic construction is developed in Section 9, after the construction of its target in Section 8.

1.1 A geometric operator and its analytic realization

Let M be a Riemannian manifold without boundary and let $E \to M$ be a finite-rank Hermitian vector bundle of positive rank. A Dirac-type operator is a formally symmetric first-order differential operator

$$D : C_c^\infty(M, E) \longrightarrow C_c^\infty(M, E)$$

whose square is of Laplace type. Thus its leading second-order part is determined by the Riemannian metric. For a geometric Dirac operator, this takes the more precise form of a Weitzenbock formula

$$D^2 = (\nabla^E)^* \nabla^E + \mathcal{R}, \tag{1.1}$$

where $\mathcal{R}$ is the curvature endomorphism described in Proposition 2.8. Examples include $d + d^*$ on differential forms and the spin Dirac operator. Adding a potential preserves the principal symbol (Proposition 2.7); Callias potentials impose additional conditions which make their contribution to positivity explicit (Definition 2.10 and Proposition 2.11).

The principal symbol recovers the Riemannian metric. By Proposition 2.2 and (2.4),

$$[D, f] = c(df), \qquad c(df)^* c(df) = |df|^2 \mathrm{id}_E$$

for every real-valued smooth function f. Thus the pointwise operator norm is $\|c(df_x)\| = |df_x|$. If df is bounded, the commutator, initially defined on compactly supported smooth sections, extends to a bounded multiplication operator with

$$\|[D, f]\|_{B(L^2(M,E))} = \|df\|_\infty.$$

The pointwise identity determines the norm of every cotangent vector, since each such vector is df_x for a suitable f.

Example 1.1. Justify the equality between the operator norm of multiplication by $c(df)$ and $\|df\|_\infty$. Further explain how one can recover the Riemannian metric from these norms. □

To discuss the spectrum, we must regard D as an unbounded operator on $L^2(M, E)$ and specify its domain. Write D_0 for the initial operator with domain $C_c^\infty(M, E)$. Formal symmetry of D_0 does not by itself imply selfadjointness.

Example 1.2. The operator $D_0 = i\partial_x$ on $C_c^\infty((0,1)) \subseteq L^2((0,1))$ is symmetric. We consider symmetric extensions $D_\pm$ with domains

$$\operatorname{dom}(D_\pm) = \{f \in C^\infty([0,1]) : f(0) = \pm f(1)\}.$$

Indeed, integration by parts gives the boundary terms $i(f(1)\overline{g(1)} - f(0)\overline{g(0)})$ which vanish if both f and g are in $\operatorname{dom}(D_\pm)$. The operators $D_\pm$ happen to be essentially selfadjoint, see Proposition 3.18.

The functions $e^{-2\pi i n x}$ and $e^{-2\pi i(n+1/2)x}$, $n \in \mathbb{Z}$, form orthonormal eigenbases for the selfadjoint closures $\bar{D}_+$ and $\bar{D}_-$, respectively. Hence

$$\sigma(\bar{D}_+) = 2\pi\mathbb{Z}, \qquad \sigma(\bar{D}_-) = 2\pi(\mathbb{Z} + 1/2).$$

For λ outside the respective set, $(\lambda - \bar{D}_\pm)^{-1}$ exists as a bounded operator.

This example shows that the choice of a selfadjoint extension matters if we are interested in spectral properties. □

Note that the interval $(0,1)$ is not complete as a Riemannian manifold. The following says that there is no choice on complete Riemannian manifolds.

Theorem 1.3 (Analytic starting point)**.** *On a complete Riemannian manifold without boundary, a formally symmetric Dirac-type operator D_0 is essentially selfadjoint.*

Its closure $\overline{D_0}$ is the unique selfadjoint extension of D_0. This is Theorem 3.13.

From now on, D denotes this selfadjoint realization unless an initial domain is specified. On an incomplete manifold, essential selfadjointness can fail, see Example 1.2. The domain is part of the spectral problem.

1.2 Which part of the spectrum is stable?

For the selfadjoint realization $(D, \mathtt{dom}(D))$ (which we abbreviate just by D), the spectrum $\sigma(D)$ is a closed subset of $\mathbb{R}$. Its different parts respond differently to geometric changes. The *essential spectrum* is what remains after removing isolated eigenvalues of finite multiplicity. It is invariant under relatively compact perturbations, and suitable changes confined to a compact region leave it unchanged. This makes geometry at infinity central to its study. The precise perturbation and decomposition statements are Theorem 4.5 and the decomposition principle, Theorem 4.9.

Individual eigenvalues can move under small perturbations. Changes in a compact region may create eigenvalues in a gap of the essential spectrum. Their positions and multiplicities are often difficult to compute, although they may carry substantial geometric or arithmetic information. Spectral problems involving automorphic forms provide one source of such questions.

The continuous spectral subspace further splits into absolutely continuous and singular continuous parts. Scattering theory studies the absolutely continuous part and its stability under suitable decay or trace-class hypotheses. Stability of the essential spectrum as a set does not by itself imply stability of this finer spectral type. We will mainly need the distinction between discrete and essential spectrum, together with estimates near zero.

Example 1.4. Start with $D_0 = -i\, d/dx$ on $C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}) \subseteq L^2(\mathbb{R})$. Its selfadjoint closure has domain $H^1(\mathbb{R})$. Under the unitary Fourier transform it becomes multiplication by ξ with domain

$$\{v \in L^2(\mathbb{R}) : \xi v(\xi) \in L^2(\mathbb{R})\}.$$

Its spectrum is $\mathbb{R}$ and is purely absolutely continuous, but its L^2-kernel is zero. Thus absence of harmonic sections does not imply invertibility. In particular, counting kernel dimensions does not detect continuous spectrum at zero. See the line calculation in Section 4.8 and the approximate-eigenvector criterion in Theorem 4.3.

Example 1.5. We will see later that $i\, d/dx$ on $\mathbb{R}$ has a non-trivial coarse index. Since this index is unchanged by bounded selfadjoint potentials and vanishes for invertible operators, such a potential cannot create a spectral gap at zero. Applying the same argument after subtracting a real constant excludes a gap anywhere else.

In contrast, the operator

$$D := \begin{pmatrix} i\, d/dx & 0 \\ 0 & -i\, d/dx \end{pmatrix}$$

on $L^2(\mathbb{R}, \mathbb{C}^2)$ has zero coarse index: its two summands have opposite index classes. For $\epsilon > 0$, consider the constant selfadjoint potential

$$V := \begin{pmatrix} 0 & \epsilon \\ \epsilon & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \|V\| = \epsilon.$$

Since $DV + VD = 0$ and $V^2 = \epsilon^2 \mathrm{id}$, we obtain

$$(D+V)^2 = \left(-\frac{d^2}{dx^2} + \epsilon^2\right) \mathrm{id} \geq \epsilon^2 \mathrm{id}.$$

Thus $D + V$ is invertible and has a spectral gap $(-\epsilon, \epsilon)$. In fact, Fourier transformation gives

$$\sigma(D+V) = (-\infty, -\epsilon] \cup [\epsilon, \infty).$$

This illustrates how in the case of a trivial coarse index adding an arbitrarily small potential can open a gap. □

1.3 The spectrum near zero and index obstructions

For a selfadjoint operator, invertibility means that zero is outside the spectrum. Equivalently, there is $\varepsilon > 0$ such that

$$\|Du\| \geq \varepsilon \|u\| \qquad (u \in \mathrm{dom}(D)). \tag{1.2}$$

The estimate implies closed range and zero kernel. Selfadjointness then implies that the range is also dense, so D^{-1} exists and is bounded, with $\|D^{-1}\| \leq \varepsilon^{-1}$. Conversely, a bounded inverse gives the estimate. For Dirac operators it suffices to establish this bound on the initial core; see Corollary 3.17. An index extracts stable information about the obstruction to such invertibility, usually with prescribed symmetries.

Consider first a compact manifold and an odd Dirac operator on a $\mathbb{Z}/2$-graded bundle $E = E^+ \oplus E^-$. Its closure has the form

$$D = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & D^- \\ D^+ & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad D^- = (D^+)^*.$$

The chiral operator D^+, viewed as a bounded map $H^1(M, E^+) \to L^2(M, E^-)$, is Fredholm, and

$$\mathrm{index}(D^+) = \dim \ker D^+ - \dim \ker D^- \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

This integer is unchanged by compact perturbations and is zero if D is invertible.

Let $F : H^+ \to H^-$ be a bounded Fredholm operator. There is a finite-rank operator $T : H^+ \to H^-$ such that $F + T$ is invertible if and only if $\mathrm{index}(F) = 0$. This can be applied to the chiral part of the bounded transform $D(1 + D^2)^{-1/2}$.

Keeping the grading matters. An ungraded selfadjoint Fredholm operator has ordinary Fredholm index zero, and its finite-dimensional kernel can always be shifted away from zero by a finite-rank selfadjoint perturbation. The index of D^+ instead obstructs an invertible compact perturbation respecting the odd graded form.

The fact that the obstruction to invertible perturbations is given by an integer is related to the K-theory fact $K_0(\mathbb{K}) \cong \mathbb{Z}$.

On a noncompact manifold, a Dirac operator need not be Fredholm. We must replace $K(\mathbb{K})$ by a K-theory of an algebra which also records where an operator acts and how far it moves sections. The coarse index in coarse K-homology provides such a replacement. Its nonvanishing obstructs invertibility, while its vanishing need not make the original operator invertible. The analytic index construction and its vanishing property are discussed in Section 9.

1.4 From functional calculus to coarse geometry

The analytic construction leading to the coarse index class rests on three facts: essential selfadjointness (Theorem 3.13), finite propagation of e^{itD} (Theorem 5.7), and local compactness of $h(D)$ for $h \in C_0(\mathbb{R})$ (Lemma 4.6). The last property means that multiplication by a compactly supported continuous function on either side makes $h(D)$ compact; compare Definition 6.7.

For h with integrable, compactly supported Fourier transform, Proposition 5.13 expresses $h(D)$ using wave operators for bounded times. It therefore has finite propagation. Approximation extends the construction to every $h \in C_0(\mathbb{R})$, giving

$$h(D) \in C^*(M, E).$$

Here $C^*(M, E)$ is the norm closure of the locally compact finite propagation operators on $L^2(M, E)$ (Definition 6.10). This functional calculus statement is Theorem 6.20. Taking account of gradings and Clifford actions turns the functional calculus homomorphism into the index class.

The geometric Roe algebra uses the controlled Hilbert space $L^2(M, E)$, but the target of the index should depend on M rather than on the particular bundle. The Roe category (Definition 6.13) supplies such a target: its K-theory is, by definition, $K\mathcal{X}(M)$. For proper metric spaces, an ample Roe algebra gives an equivalent K-theory model by Theorem 8.21. Stabilization of the geometric module, when necessary, allows us to use this comparison.

Coarse geometry abstracts the data entering this construction. A bornological coarse space is a set with a coarse structure, which controls propagation, and a compatible bornology, which specifies the bounded regions used for formulating local compactness (Definition 7.1). Its morphisms are proper controlled maps (Definition 7.6). The resulting functor

$$K\mathcal{X} : \mathbf{BC} \longrightarrow \mathbf{Sp}$$

is a coarse homology theory by Theorem 8.19. The axioms are given in Definition 8.4. In particular, it inverts coarse equivalences, such as $\mathbb{Z}^n \hookrightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ (Lemma 8.5 and Example 7.9).

Excision and vanishing on flasques yield

$$K\mathcal{X}(\mathbb{R}^n) \simeq \Sigma^n KU, \tag{1.3}$$

by Proposition 8.9 and Proposition 8.20.

1.5 Positivity, support, and scalar curvature

The local formula (1.1) yields a global estimate when its endomorphism term has a uniform positive lower bound. If $\mathcal{R} \geq \varepsilon^2 \mathrm{id}_E$ everywhere, then integration by parts gives

$$\|Du\|^2 = \|\nabla^E u\|^2 + \langle \mathcal{R}u, u\rangle \geq \varepsilon^2 \|u\|^2$$

for compactly supported smooth u. The estimate extends to the selfadjoint domain and implies invertibility; see Corollaries 2.9 and 3.17.

For the untwisted spin Dirac operator on a complete spin manifold, the Lichnerowicz formula (2.6) reads

$$D^2 = \nabla^*\nabla + \frac{\mathrm{scal}_g}{4}.$$

Consequently a uniform bound $\mathrm{scal}_g \geq c > 0$ implies a spectral gap and

$$\operatorname{ind} \mathcal{X}(D) = 0. \tag{1.4}$$

On a compact manifold, strict positivity supplies a uniform lower bound automatically. On a noncompact manifold, the condition $\mathrm{scal}_g(x) > 0$ at each point does not by itself supply the estimate needed here.

Uniform positivity outside a subset A has a more local consequence. It gives an index with support near A, whose image is the global coarse index. The support is expressed by the big family $\langle A\rangle$ of (7.2); its operator model is the support ideal of Definition 6.17. The supported index is discussed in Section 9.12. If A is compact, Corollary 4.10 gives a gap in the essential spectrum and hence Fredholmness, but discrete eigenvalues near zero may remain. Positivity outside A therefore need not imply invertibility on the whole manifold.

The contrapositive of (1.4) produces obstructions to uniformly positive scalar curvature. In comparing different metrics, one must also compare their coarse structures and the index classes in a common target. The course will formulate this compatibility rather than treating the target group as independent of every change of metric. When the primary index vanishes because of positivity, the corresponding trivialization can carry additional information. This leads to secondary, or ρ-, invariants of positive scalar curvature metrics.

1.6 Decomposition and escape to infinity

A useful index theory must permit calculations. Coarse homology theories satisfy excision, expressed by a Mayer–Vietoris sequence for suitable decompositions. If $M = M_- \cup M_+$ is coarsely excisive in the sense of Definition 8.6, Proposition 8.7 provides a boundary map

$$\partial : K\mathcal{X}_j(M) \longrightarrow K\mathcal{X}_{j-1}(M_- \cap M_+).$$

For a manifold partitioned by a hypersurface, with compatible Dirac data and product structure near the hypersurface, the partitioned index theorem identifies the boundary of the index with the hypersurface index, with compatible orientation conventions. This reduces a geometric calculation by one dimension.

Another basic mechanism is the Eilenberg swindle. On a ray, a controlled shift pushes the entire space away from every bounded subset. An infinite direct sum of successive shifts absorbs one additional copy. Additivity then forces the coarse K-homology of the ray to vanish. Spaces admitting the requisite uniformly controlled shift are called flasque (Definition 8.1). Example 8.2 checks the ray, and the proof of Theorem 8.19 implements the swindle in the Roe category.

Example 1.6. Both closed half-lines are flasque. Excision for their union $\mathbb{R}$ therefore gives

$$K\mathcal{X}(\mathbb{R}) \simeq \Sigma K\mathcal{X}(*).$$

Iteration and $K\mathcal{X}(*) \simeq KU$ give (1.3); the corresponding groups are computed in (8.6). Thus the vanishing on rays is compatible with nonvanishing on the whole line. Translating the line does not push its entire image away from a bounded set. We will prove these statements directly from the axioms in Section 8.

1.7 The symbol, the index map, and assembly

The passage from a Dirac operator to its index has a homotopy-theoretic interpretation. The cone construction of Section 10 gives a functor $\mathcal{O}^\infty : \mathbf{UBC} \to \mathbf{BC}$, where **UBC** denotes uniform bornological coarse spaces. We define local K-homology by

$$K^{\mathcal{X}} := \Sigma^{-1} K\mathcal{X} \circ \mathcal{O}^\infty : \mathbf{UBC} \longrightarrow \mathbf{Sp}.$$

The cone boundary and coarse suspension give the index map

$$a : K^{\mathcal{X}} \longrightarrow K\mathcal{X} \circ \iota,$$

where $\iota : \mathbf{UBC} \to \mathbf{BC}$ forgets the uniform structure. Section 11 will construct the symbol class $\sigma(D)$ in local K-homology $K^{\mathcal{X}}(M)$ and establish

$$a_M(\sigma(D)) = \operatorname{ind} \mathcal{X}(D).$$

The index map a_M makes the transition from the symbol to the analytic index accessible to methods of homotopy theory. For example, naturality shows that the index map is compatible with Mayer–Vietoris boundaries. Support conditions refine both its source and its target.

Coarse assembly applies this construction at increasing scales. For a symmetric entourage U containing the diagonal, the Rips complex $P_U(Z)$ has as simplices the finite subsets $F \subseteq Z$ with $F \times F \subseteq U$. With the standard uniform and bornological coarse structures on these complexes, the spectrum-level assembly map is the map

$$\mu_Z : \operatorname*{colim}_{U \in \mathcal{C}} K^{\mathcal{X}}(P_U(Z)) \longrightarrow K\mathcal{X}(Z).$$

induced by the index maps of the uniform bornological coarse spaces $P_U(Z)$ and the identifications $\mathtt{colim}_{U \in \mathcal{C}} K\mathcal{X}(P_U(Z)) \simeq K\mathcal{X}(Z)$. Here $\mathcal{C}$ is the poset of coarse entourages of Z. The Rips colimit is a coarsification, as explained in Section 8. The coarse Baum–Connes problem asks under which coarse geometric hypotheses assembly μ_Z is an equivalence.

1.8 Plan of the course

The first part develops the analytic foundations. Section 2 introduces Dirac bundles, their operators, and positivity formulas. Section 3 constructs selfadjoint realizations, and Section 4 studies spectral stability and examples. Section 5 provides the propagation and functional calculus estimates used in the index construction.

The second part introduces the geometric target. Section 6 constructs controlled Hilbert spaces and Roe algebras. Section 7 formulates boundedness and control independently of a metric. Section 8 develops coarse homology theories, Rips coarsification, and coarse K-homology, together with their first calculations.

Section 9 constructs the coarse index class. Sections 10 and 11 then develop the cone construction and the index map. Section 12 combines analytic vanishing with topological calculations to obtain applications to positive scalar curvature. The aim is to understand both the construction of the invariant and the geometric arguments which make it useful.

1.9 References and further reading

The following references complement the exposition of this course. Roe's books provide an entry into coarse geometry and its connection with index theory; the analytic references supply background for Dirac operators and their spectra. The final group develops the operator-algebraic and homotopy-theoretic index constructions.

Coarse geometry and coarse homology.

1. J. Roe, *Lectures on Coarse Geometry*, University Lecture Series **31**, American Mathematical Society, 2003 (publisher). A systematic introduction to coarse spaces, translation algebras, asymptotic dimension, and coarse embeddings. This is background for Sections 6 and 7.

2. U. Bunke and A. Engel, *Homotopy Theory with Bornological Coarse Spaces*, Lecture Notes in Mathematics **2269**, Springer, 2020 (publisher; arXiv:1607.03657). The reference for the axiomatic framework used in Sections 7 and 8, including coarse homology theories, coarsification, and coarse K-homology.

Dirac operators, spectral theory, and analytic foundations.

1. H. B. Lawson, Jr., and M.-L. Michelsohn, *Spin Geometry*, Princeton Mathematical Series **38**, Princeton University Press, 1989 (book). Background on Clifford algebras, spinor bundles, Dirac operators, and index theory, especially relevant to Section 2 and the scalar-curvature applications.

2. T. Friedrich, *Dirac Operators in Riemannian Geometry*, Graduate Studies in Mathematics **25**, American Mathematical Society, 2000 (publisher). A geometric introduction emphasizing spinors, curvature identities, and eigenvalue estimates for the Dirac operator.

3. J. Roe, *Elliptic Operators, Topology and Asymptotic Methods*, second edition, Pitman Research Notes in Mathematics **395**, Longman, 1998 (publisher). An introduction to elliptic analysis and the heat-kernel proof of the index theorem, complementing the functional calculus and heat operator discussion in Section 5.

4. T. Kato, *Perturbation Theory for Linear Operators*, Classics in Mathematics, Springer, 1995, reprint of the 1980 edition (publisher). A general reference for closed operators, selfadjointness, and spectral perturbation theory, providing analytic background for Sections 3 and 4.

5. J. Eichhorn, *Elliptic differential operators on noncompact manifolds*, in *Seminar Analysis of the Karl-Weierstrass-Institute of Mathematics, 1986/87*, Teubner-Texte zur Mathematik **106**, Teubner, Leipzig, 1988, pp. 4–169. An early systematic treatment of elliptic operators on noncompact manifolds, providing foundations for the analysis of Dirac operators on complete manifolds. This is background for the selfadjointness, spectral theory, and analytic estimates in Sections 3–5.

6. P. R. Chernoff, *Essential self-adjointness of powers of generators of hyperbolic equations*, Journal of Functional Analysis **12** (1973), 401–414 (article). A foundational source on essential selfadjointness through hyperbolic propagation, including powers of Dirac operators on complete manifolds. Compare Theorems 3.13 and 5.7, and Proposition 5.9.

7. C. Bär, *The Dirac operator on hyperbolic manifolds of finite volume*, Journal of Differential Geometry **54** (2000), 439–488 (arXiv:math/0010233). A detailed noncompact spectral example: the spin structure affects whether the spectrum is discrete or fills the real line. This complements the discussion of geometry at infinity in Section 4.

Coarse index theory, assembly, and positive scalar curvature.

1. J. Roe, *Index Theory, Coarse Geometry, and Topology of Manifolds*, CBMS Regional Conference Series in Mathematics **90**, American Mathematical Society, 1996 (publisher). A concise introduction to the interaction between index theory, coarse geometry, operator algebras, and assembly, including methods for calculating coarse indices.

2. N. Higson and J. Roe, *Analytic K-Homology*, Oxford University Press, 2000 (publisher). Analytic foundations for K-homology, operator-theoretic index classes, and assembly maps. This provides background for the passage from a Dirac operator to its symbol and index classes.

3. R. Willett and G. Yu, *Higher Index Theory*, Cambridge University Press, 2020 (publisher). A modern treatment of Roe and localization algebras, differential operators, and higher assembly maps; a complementary approach to Sections 6–11.

4. J. Roe, *Positive curvature, partial vanishing theorems, and coarse indices*, preprint, 2012 (arXiv:1210.6100). Explains localization of the coarse index when the Weitzenbock curvature term is uniformly positive away from a subset. This is directly relevant to Section 9.12.

5. U. Bunke and A. Engel, *The coarse index class with support* (arXiv:1706.06959). The main reference for the categorical construction followed in Section 9, including the comparison with Roe algebras and index classes with support.

6. U. Bunke and A. Engel, *Coarse assembly maps* (arXiv:1706.02164). Develops assembly for coarse homology theories and identifies its source using locally finite homology. This is background for the cone and index maps in Sections 10 and 11.

7. U. Bunke and M. Ludewig, *Coronas and Callias type operators in coarse geometry* (arXiv:2411.01646). Relates local symbols, support conditions, corona pairings, and coarse indices of Callias type operators. It also treats compatibility with partitions and Mayer–Vietoris boundaries, extending the perspective of this course.